From here on, Krenz and his plotters sat tight but were manoeuvring behind the scenes. Honecker hobbled back to work in late September. The overwhelming impression from those near him was of a man who was out of touch, who was all too human – who lectured, changed his mind, spoke too much and yet did too little. After months in hospital, Honecker, the bright political schemer, was nowhere to be seen.

His return to duty coincided with the rise of an independent political party called ‘New Forum,’ which used a simple battle cry to demand dialogue about democratic reforms and reshaping society. Founded by a disparate collection of artists, intellectuals and environmentalists, the SED dubbed the movement illegal and denied it official recognition. Adding to the chorus calling for reforms, the East German Social Democratic Party (created in July, of which seven of fourteen founders were clergymen), was followed by a group called ‘Democratic Re-Awakening’. Meanwhile, on the streets of the GDR, young, braver spirits continued Monday evening protests in Leipzig, taunting the police with cries of ‘Gorby will get you’, and ‘We want out of this shithouse.’ When Honecker ordered Neues Deutschland to label those emigrating as ‘counter-revolutionaries’, many protesters changed their tune and began chanting: ‘We want to stay’, underlining their desire for change at home rather than a new life in the West. To cement that point, New Forum’s manifesto demanded greater freedoms within the East German state rather than emigration. And Konrad Weiss, the leader of ‘Democracy Now’ – another new group made up of intellectuals – feared the GDR could be annexed as a ‘state’ within the FRG.

Amid all this, Soviet Central Committee secretary Vadim Medvedev, in charge of relations with socialist countries and ideology, was conducting a lighting tour of East Berlin. He returned home ‘with grave thoughts’, concluding: ‘the first thing one should have done – was to take a decision on the change of leadership’20 (referring to Honecker). Furthermore, he wailed that most of Honecker’s cadres were also inflexibly resistant to change.21 Seemingly oblivious to events, GDR television – still habitually self-censoring – continued to push forward a steady stream of fawning stories about the ruling party. On 2 October, the evening news led with a report on Honecker’s ‘friendly encounter’ with British tycoon Robert